companies on existing pack-animal trails via central Tibet. The Chinese, for their part, declared that they planned to station ‘technicians’ along the route through Tibet to ‘facilitate transport’.[93]

The Tibetans refused. The Chinese government then tried another ruse. A representative of its Ministry of Communications would negotiate arrangements directly with Tibetan trading companies in Kalimpong in northern Bengal. The British agreed to this, but the Tibetans, once again, saw a hidden agenda behind the Chinese proposal and declared that no Tibetan trading companies would be allowed to enter into such agreements without the approval of the authorities in Lhasa.

Meanwhile, the Americans, through their Office of Strategic Services (OSS), proposed to send intelligence officers to Tibet to survey the terrain. The idea of constructing a motorable road from India and through Tibet to China had not been totally discarded. After some initial difficulties, two Americans, Ilia Tolstoy and Brooke Dolan, were granted entry to Tibet. The American position was to support the Republic of China and its territorial claims, but Tolstoy made promises to the Tibetans that probably went beyond official policy. He said that he would recommend to his government that Tibet should be represented at a peace conference, which was going to be held after the war. The kashag was excited, and saw it as the first opportunity since the Shimla Conference to push for international recognition of its independence.

The British, on the other hand, were watching China’s manoeuvres with increasing concern. On 29 April 1943, the Foreign Office in London sent a proposal to the India Office that Britain should withdraw its previous recognition of Chinese suzerainty over Tibet. The Foreign Office stated in its letter that such a withdrawal would be in Britain’s and India’s interest, as it would then be easier to settle once and for all the question of the border between India and Tibet.[94]

In the end, Britain decided that altering its policy on the status of Tibet might provoke the Chinese to attack and even occupy Tibet. The Republic of China would probably have tried to invade Tibet anyway once World War II was over, but the civil war with the communists kept the KMT occupied on other, more crucial fronts. The communist victory and the proclamation of the People’s Republic of China on 1 October 1949 changed all that—and that was when Mao Zedong made his famous pledge